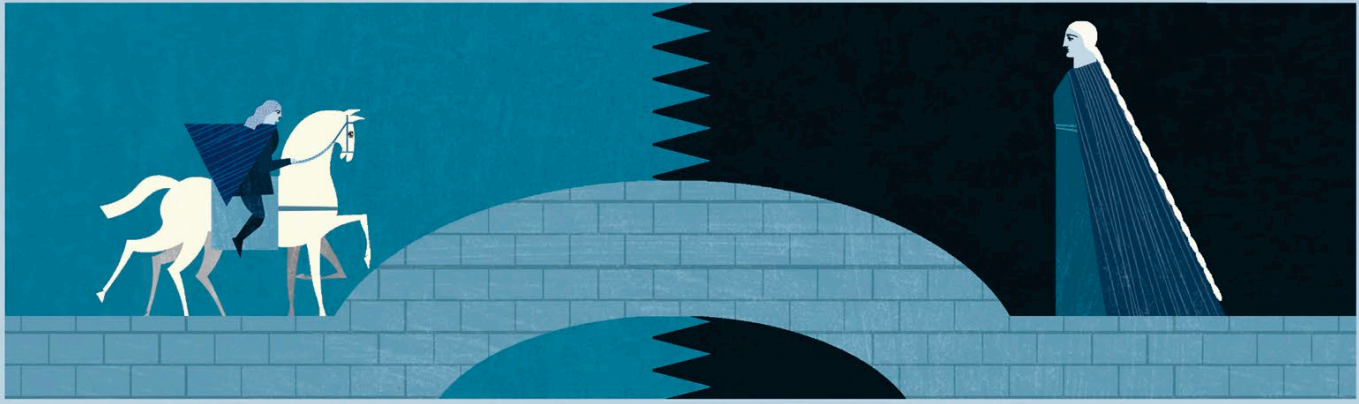




Halfway across the golden-roofed bridge that spanned it, he was met by a fearsome warrior woman called Modgud. “I’ve come to bargain with Hel,” said Hermod. “The Aesir seek the return of Baldr.”

“Baldr crossed my bridge nine days ago,” Modgud replied. “I will let you pass – but be warned, Hel will demand a high price for his return.”

Hermod rode swiftly down and into darkness. Ice gleamed on the valley walls, and the air was brittle with cold. On, on, on he raced until up loomed the gates of Niflheim. Sleipnir cleared them in a single jump, and soon Hermod found Baldr, sitting next to Hel in the land of the dead. “What do you want, Hermod?” she said, words falling from her mouth like dead crows.

“We gods wail and weep for our lost brother,” said Hermod. “I ask that you allow him to return to the light, and those who love him.”

